



THE ANVIL



MACG

NEWSLETTER OF THE MELBOURNE ANARCHIST COMMUNIST GROUP

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Free

DEFEND THE CFMEU

The attacks on the CFMEU have more to do with the interests of capital than any organised crime within the union.

The capitalist media in Australia have launched a massive propaganda attack on the Construction & General Division of the Construction, Forestry & Maritime Employees Union (CFMEU). Though initiated by Nine Entertainment, the battle has been joined by all organs of the media, from the ABC to the Murdoch gutter press. The capitalist class sees an opportunity to smash the strongest union in the country and drive down wages for the best paid section of the working class, with inevitable flow on effects for all workers. This is class war.

Grainy footage leaked by the cops and a handful of workplace delegates who are former bikies have been woven up to create a story of a thoroughly corrupt union. We'll be honest – there are corrupt union officials, and they should be disposed of. Any official who takes a bribe should have a black mark against their name for eternity. But the attacks on the CFMEU are not about union corruption, they are about breaking the wages and conditions of construction workers. Governments have been



Artist: Sam Wallman

happy to let developers rip vast sums off buyers in high-rise residential towers that were never fit for habitation and allow standover merchants to settle disputes between contractors, so they can't be believed when they say they want to root corruption out of the CFMEU.

It is the job of members to organise against corruption in the union movement and root it out. "Unions" like Shop Distributive and Allied (the SDA) routinely collude with big business to hold down the wages of retail and fast food workers.



What is Anarchism?

Anarchism is a social philosophy based upon the principles of liberty, equality and solidarity. It is the political dimension of a free society.

What is Communism?

Communism is the principle of “from each according to their ability, to each according to their need”. It is the economic dimension of a free society.

What is the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group?

The MACG is an organisation of class struggle revolutionary anarchists who share political positions, articulated in theory, strategy and tactics.

We aim to encourage struggle by the working class for its own interests and, within that struggle, we aim to advance Anarchist ideas as its necessary philosophical basis.

The Australian Workers Union (AWU) undermines wages and safety in civil construction, cleaning, road works and more. The ACTU and ALP affiliated unions routinely put the electoral interests of the ALP ahead of workers.

The CFMEU's real crime is that they have achieved a de facto closed shop over the state government's "Big Build" and much of the city's high rise development. In theory, the AWU have coverage over civil construction, but the CFMEU drove them out by delivering much better wages and conditions. This is a good thing. ACTU coverage rules allow Australia's Worst Union to operate by undercutting wages and safety conditions in order to get preferential treatment from the bosses. When the capitalist press says "we all pay" for the CFMEU, what they mean is that construction workers wages should be lower.

The last Liberal government launched a Royal Commission into Trade Union Corruption, targeted squarely at the CFMEU. No substantive prosecutions resulted. They re-established the Australian Building and Construction Commission (ABCC), tasked with fining the CFMEU out of existence. They did not succeed. They passed laws to enable the Fair Work Commission to place unions into administration, but they didn't dare use them.



Credit: Labor Notes

Continued ...



Credit: theconversation.com

The Labor government, ever keen to demonstrate their reliability to capital, has now moved to crush the CFMEU. In less than a week, Albanese has moved to do what the Liberals never could.

The Federal Labor government has asked the Fair Work Commission to apply to the Federal Court to place branches of the CFMEU into external administration. An administrator would be able to act as the union, taking over its assets, firing union staff, purging members, removing delegates, and ousting officials.

But the real prize of administration is the ability to rip up Enterprise Agreements (EBAs). Labor have made clear they are prepared to pass special legislation to give any administrator “full powers” to “act in the public interest”. An administrator appointed by the Fair Work Commission, acting as the union, will have little trouble applying to the Commission to terminate union agreements and drive union members down to the award (industry specific minimum pay and conditions) – which, in construction, is vastly below industry standards.

Government administration of a union is an affront to the very concept of

unionism. Workers build unions in order to build their collective strength, and coordinate their collective action. We fight to defend unions as organisations built by workers, consisting of workers, and democratically controlled by workers. In the face of union corruption, we have to organise and overthrow corrupt or self interested officials. The only people who should be “cleaning the house” are union members.

The ALP is historically a party of the trade union bureaucracy. Through the ALP, the trade union bureaucracy attempts to negotiate a compromise with capital on the overall management of capitalism in Australia. In 2021-2024 the CFMEU gave \$4.3 million to the ALP, stumping up a sizeable portion of the funding to get Anthony Albanese elected. Albanese and the ALP are now moving to destroy the CFMEU. There is a lesson in this. The interests of individual union leadership (let alone any group of workers) will always come second to the collective interest the ALP has in perpetuating its own position as a party of government within Australian capitalism.

The treacherous nature of the trade union bureaucracy can be seen in the actions of the ACTU. Faced with a frontal assault on the principles of trade unionism, Sally McManus and the ACTU executive demanded that “the leadership of the CFMEU ... support the appointment of an independent and external administrator and to cooperate with such an administration”. CFMEU representatives on ACTU executive were not even permitted to argue against the motion!



Credit: abc.net.au

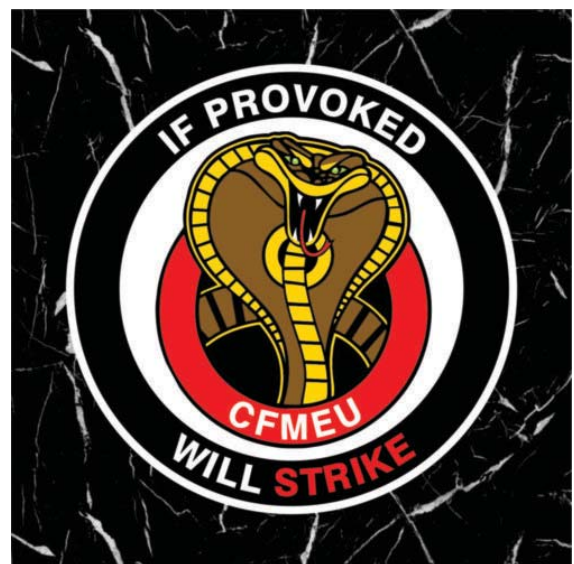
Far from supporting a government administrator, the members of the CFMEU should fight it with every tool at their disposal and call on their officials to follow them. There should be a campaign of complete non-cooperation with any government appointed administrator. The hard won pay, conditions and strength of tens of thousands of construction workers is at stake today and that of the rest of us tomorrow.

Sally McManus said she could count the unions opposing the CFMEU's suspension on one hand. It's up to the rank and file of every union to make sure that number grows. Members of every union must organise in solidarity with construction workers and their union.

Shop Stewards (delegates) on every site and in every state should establish committees for member control of the union. The moment any administrator is appointed, these committees should simply act as the union. Officials and employees of the CFMEU Construction and General Division should recognise these committees and take direction from

them. As part of this, CFMEU officials and elected leaders should hand over all readily available resources (especially contact lists) to such committees before administration comes into effect, and in defiance of the law once it is in effect.

The Shop Stewards committees should begin immediate work to organise resistance against administration and to defend EBAs and coverage, in particular on all Big Build projects. As soon as administration is in effect, members should organise to divert payment of all union dues to those committees.



Credit: cfmeu

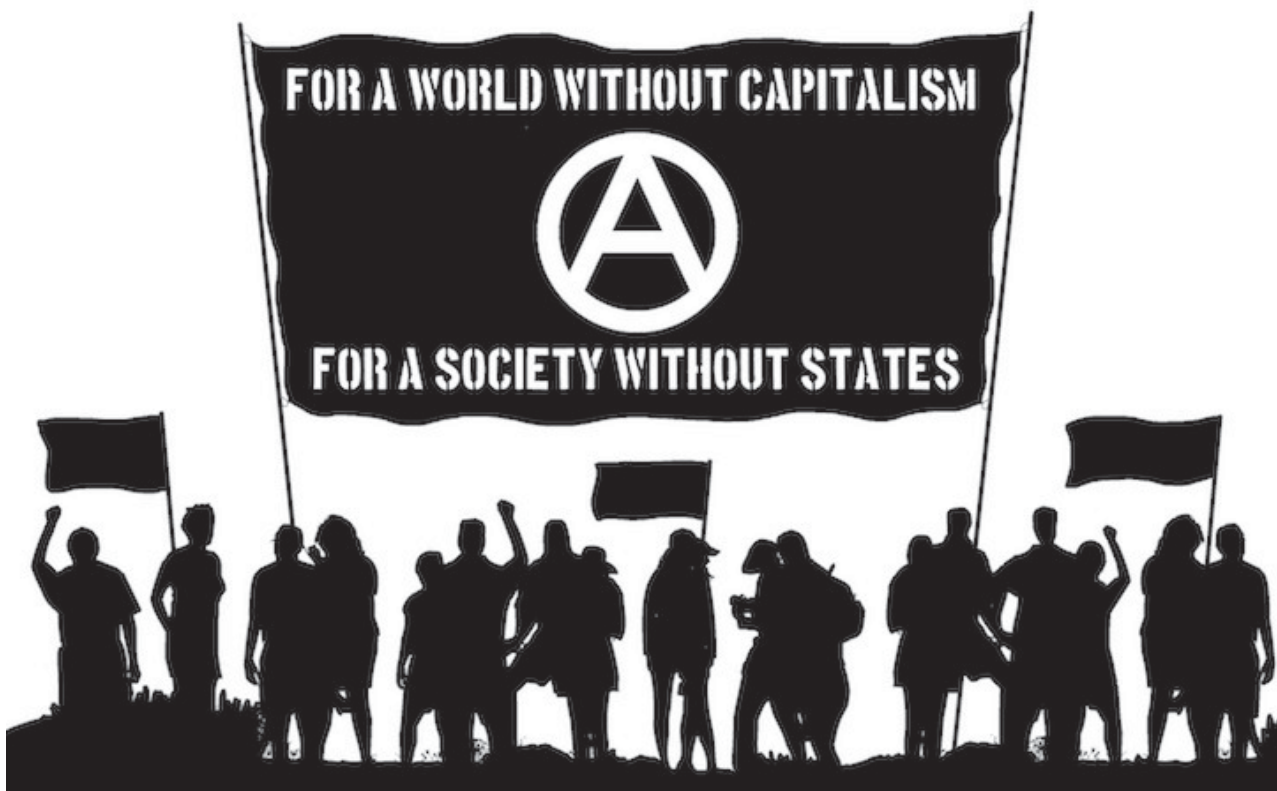
The governments' attacks on the CFMEU can be defeated. The CFMEU must be defended. It is essential that all union members fight to defend the principle of independent trade unions under member control.

An attack on one union is an attack on all unions, and an attack on unions is an attack on all workers.

**TOUCH ONE
TOUCH ALL**

ANARCHISM 101: Organisational Dualism

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Source: anarchistrevolt.com

The Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group follows the approach known as 'organisational dualism' – a strategy which dates back to the beginning of the anarchist movement. We argue that anarchists need to be organised at two levels: the 'political' level and the 'mass' level.

Politically, we organise among ourselves as anarchists. We advocate formal organisations which operate on the basis of theoretical unity, a shared strategy, and collective responsibility. The basis for organisation at the political level is ideological. The political organisation unites convinced revolutionaries and multiplies our efforts to intervene as an anarchist minority within the broader working class movement.

At the same time, we organise alongside our fellow workers wherever we can

unite as a class in direct struggle against exploitation and oppression. Despite their bureaucratisation, the largest and most important mass organisations of this kind are the trade unions. The basis for organisation at the mass level is not ideological, but a willingness to fight together as workers – as a class.

We see the distinction between political and mass organisations as vital. An anarchist political organisation requires a high level of political agreement, so that we can maintain a clear analysis and strategy while adapting to new developments in the class struggle. Meanwhile, mass organisations should unite as many workers as possible. Political organisations can't be so broad that they become incoherent, and mass organisations like unions shouldn't impose a strict political test before workers can join.

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We reject the strategy of separating ourselves from the mass of workers by forming explicitly ideological unions. We do want anarchist methods of organisation and struggle to be adopted within unions and other campaigns. An 'anarchist union', however, would either isolate itself from the majority who don't already share our ideas or instantly dilute its 'anarchism' by making the majority of its members non-anarchist workers.

By grouping together all workers on the basis of class, we avoid the problem of separating more radical workers from less radical ones, and maintain the potential for those workers to be influenced in meetings and in our organising.

Organisational dualism differs from the approach of most Marxist groups in two key ways. First, anarchist political

organisations are federalist and controlled from the bottom up.

Second, we reject substituting our organisations for the working class movement. Anarchist organisations don't aim to 'lead' struggles in the sense of taking them over or giving orders from above. Instead, we fight for the leadership of our ideas and methods. Members of an anarchist political organisation are the most active and militant members of the union in their workplace and organise workplaces which are unorganised. We fight against top-down, bureaucratic organisation in both our unions and social movements and encourage direct action under the control of the rank and file. In doing so, we demonstrate the validity of our ideas and build toward the kind of self-organised working class power which will be necessary to overthrow capitalism.



Source: Zabalaza

THE CLIMATE WARS MEAN CLASS WAR



Source: Union Aid Abroad

We are deep into a dangerous crisis, a crisis so massive, there are few means by which to fight, mitigate, and survive world-wide catastrophic climate events. Such events are occurring with increasing regularity and ferociousness. The capitalist class and its ruling elite have been selling us a lie that it's our fault we are in this crisis because of the individual choices we make and that it's the accumulation of these choices that are generating greenhouse gases. The catastrophes continue to escalate and we are losing.

The dominant ideology of individualised responsibility has led to world-wide passivity in the face of impending global ecological and societal collapse. Passivity leads to blaming others for the problem and living in hope that someone else will fix it. As governments argue over meaningless zero emission targets, kicking the can further down the road, they are paying corporations globally to extract more fossil fuels and accelerate greenhouse gas emissions.

The statistics are clear as to how we have been plunged into this mess. Carbon Majors, a database operated by not-for-profit think tank Influence Map, tracked

122 of the world's largest oil, gas, coal and cement producers to quantify the production-linked operational emissions and emissions from the combustion or use of their products. The Carbon Majors database also traced cumulative emissions from 1854 to 2022 of these 122 companies. They found that they are responsible for 72% of global fossil fuel and cement CO2 emissions since 1751. Furthermore, 70% of these global CO2 emissions can be attributed to just 78 corporate and state producing entities.

There can be no faith in parliament to act. In Australia, climate deniers are now supporting costly and dangerous nuclear energy that generates waste materials that remain lethal for up to 200,000 years. The more "progressive" capitalists are, for the most part, both half-hearted in their plans and just as committed to top-down planning and profit maximisation. Their renewable energy projects are imposed from the outside, rather than being community-led, and are easy prey for right wing activists advancing bad faith opposition. They subsidise electric vehicles rather than moving to a truly sustainable transport system where the private car occupies a small residual place.

The wider shift towards batteries is being done without addressing the environmental effects of the mining industry, so damage from coal, oil and gas extraction is to be replaced by damage from nickel and lithium mining. In the struggle between the different factions of capital, saving the world from

climate change comes a distant second behind the continued maximisation of profit and the maintenance of the capitalists' control.

Capitalism is a class system. A system that sees a small ruling capitalist elite in control on the one hand and the mass of the people controlled, on the other, separated by force from controlling their own productive work. These people, the overwhelming majority, the working class, have one means of survival, to work for the capitalists for wages to buy their means to live. The domination of the ruling capitalist class is guaranteed by the power of the state, which exists for precisely that purpose. The very real threat to the health and safety of all workers is because the capitalists refuse any solution which would negatively affect their interests.

The Climate Wars Mean Class War!

Our struggle must be global. Our interests are the same as all workers across the globe. We all face catastrophe caused by capitalism. The working class has no country: we have a whole planet. We, the workers, need to act quickly to avert the inevitability of catastrophe if things continue as they are. This means asserting our collective power



Source: Extinction Rebellion

to paralyse the capitalist doomsday machine.

It is in the workplace that we have the ability to act for ourselves, without delegating control to capitalist politicians. And it is in the workplace we have the ability to take power away from the capitalists and wield it ourselves. In the struggle for the immediate goal of survival, we will find it necessary to end capitalism and establish our collective freedom. By abolishing the profit system, we can reconcile the requirement for producing the goods and services necessary for a civilised life with the necessity to live sustainably within our natural environment. We must have a just transition for all, whether it's workers in fossil fuel industries, local communities currently on the edge of viability, or anyone else. We have a world to save – and a world to win.

NO WAR BUT CLASS WAR

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